

Roman temples

Based on Greek and Etruscan forerunners, Roman temples generally centred on a main room, or cella, housing the icon of the deity to whom the temple was dedicated (and often a small altar for incense or libations). Behind this lay one or more rooms used by temple attendants for offerings. Public religious ceremonies occurred *outside* the temple building; unlike Greek temples, which looked the same from all aspects, each Roman temple had a columned portico along its front.

The most important temple in ancient Rome was the Temple of Jupiter (509 BCE), which stood on the Capitoline Hill surrounded by a precinct where assemblies met and statues and victory trophies were displayed. After the original wooden temple burned down, it was rebuilt using Greek marble columns and covered in gold and mosaic. The circular Temple of Vesta (c.100 BCE, opposite) is the oldest surviving marble building in Rome, with 20 Corinthian columns. Despite its name, it is believed to have been dedicated to Hercules Olivarius, patron god of olive oil merchants.

